peace, security and socialist construction. We were bound, duty-bound, to carry through the security measures. It was right'.

Not everybody, of course, was content to be walled in and cracks began showing almost right away. The Wall bought Cold War stability at a horrifying human price. Over the next twenty-eight years, hundreds of people would be shot dead; others drowned, suffered fatal accidents, or killed themselves when caught. Many experienced horrible injuries from shrapnel-spraying firing devices that padded the 'death strip'. The bloodletting began on 22 August 1961, when 58-year-old housewife Ida Siekmann became the first person to die while attempting to escape West. That morning, she tossed her bedding down onto the street from the fourth floor of a building on Bernauer Straße – adjacent to the Wall – then jumped out of the window crashing on the paving stones below, dying shortly afterward. Two days later, Günter Litfin, a 24-year-old tailor, was shot dead when attempting to escape by swimming from Humboldthafen to the West, not far from the main Lehrter Railway station. In an interview for this book, Litfin's brother, Jurgen, welled up as he described how Günter was cut down by machine-gun fire – the family found out about the incident on West German television. 'We were forced by the Stasi to say that Günter had been involved in an accident – my brother wasn't a troublemaker – just a modest tailor that wanted freedom. We all tolerated these communists, but, after this, secretly despised them.' Five days after Litfin's death, 27-year-old Roland Hof was shot in the Teltow Canal during an escape attempt.

On 21 November, builders ceased work on concrete barricades along the border, prompting Dennis Martin, the Berlin correspondent of the Daily Mirror to report that before leaving, builders tidied up. 'They even swept the top of the new wall at the Brandenburg Gate.' Within a few hours, the cranes, lorries and pneumatic drills – which had rumbled and hammered away for months – disappeared, leaving behind an eerie peace.

Keen to draw a veil over events at the Wall, Honecker turned his attention to other pressing issues, including preparing the so-called 'honorary service' laws, designed to draft 18–25-year-olds into the NVA, riot police, or military units of the state security for eighteen months' compulsory